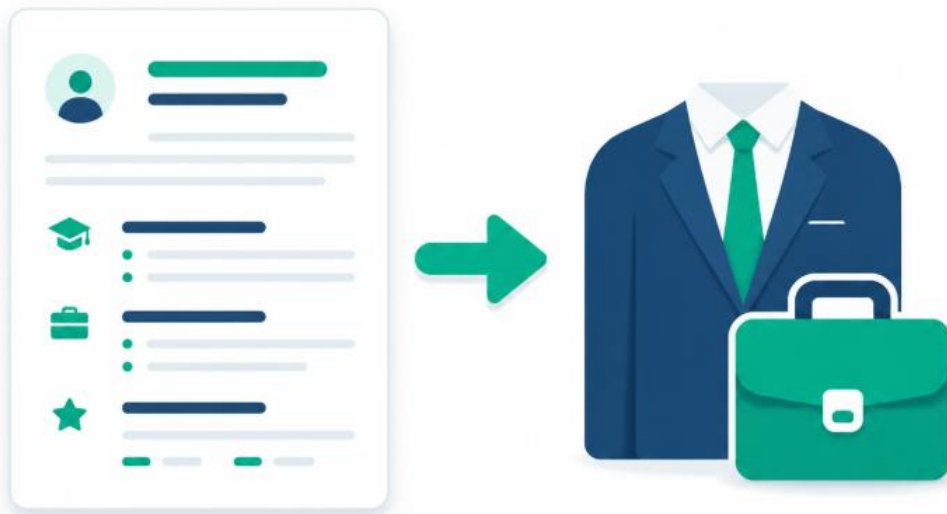


SKILLS FOR PROFESSIONAL FREELANCERS

Participants Handout

Session 5

CV Writing & Interviewing Skills



01 Session Map

Learning Objectives

- Describe how the hiring process and an ATS screen a CV.
- Explain what recruiters look for in every CV section.
- Write evidence-based bullets using action verbs and measurable results.
- Evaluate weak and strong samples, then audit your own CV.
- Use AI to tailor a CV and rehearse interview answers without inventing evidence.
- Create STAR-structured answers for competency-based interviews.

Your Workbook Journey

1. Target	2. Build	3. Prove	4. Tailor	5. Rehearse
Read the advert	Write clear sections	Add evidence	Match and verify	Answer with STAR

Bring two real inputs.

Keep your current CV and one real job advert beside this workbook. Every activity becomes stronger when the target role is specific.

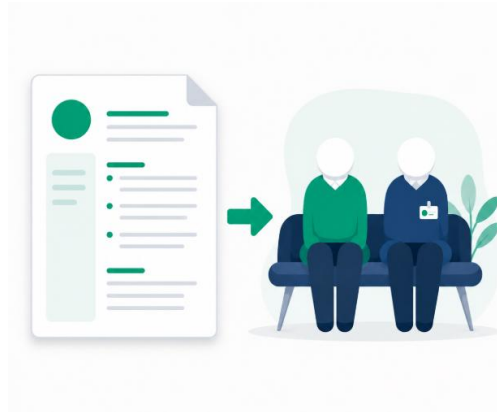
Reflect & Write

What is the biggest obstacle between your current CV and an interview invitation?

My current obstacle:

One result I want from this session:

02 The CV Has One Job



The goal is an interview.

A CV does not win the job. It earns the conversation in which you can prove your fit.

Three Shortlisting Habits

Relevance	Evidence	Visibility
Every line supports this application.	A result proves more than an adjective.	The match must be clear in seconds.

Where Your CV Enters the Hiring Process

Step	Employer Action	What It Means for You
1	Identify the hiring need	A gap opens.
2	Prepare the job description	The keywords and requirements are written.
3	Run a talent search	Your CV must be findable.
4	Screen the CVs	Your evidence must be relevant.
5	Interview candidates	Every claim may be tested.

Reflect & Write

If a recruiter gave your CV only ten seconds, which three lines should they notice first?

03 Pass the ATS Screen



An Applicant Tracking System scans CV structure and vocabulary before many recruiters read the document.

Stage	What the System Does	Your Response
Parse	Breaks the file into fields.	Use one column and standard headings.
Match	Compares fields with the advert.	Use the employer's own terms honestly.
Rank	Orders the strongest matches first.	Make evidence easy to find.

ATS-Friendly Check

- ☐ Use the advert's recognised job title.
- ☐ Write technology names in full and include common abbreviations.
- ☐ Keep headings such as Experience, Education, Skills, and Projects.
- ☐ Use one column with no text boxes, rating bars, or hidden tables.
- ☐ Keep important evidence as selectable text, never inside an image.

Rules my CV already passes	
Highest-risk formatting issue	
Keyword missing from my CV	

04 Build the Right CV Structure



The Standard Sections

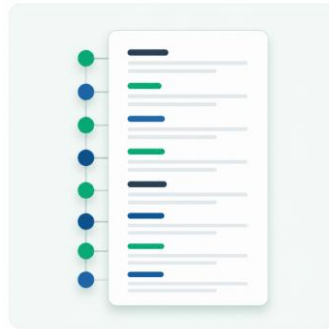
Section	What a Recruiter Looks For	Priority
Contact Information	Fast, professional ways to reach you.	Always
Career Objective / Summary	Role, level, tools, and value.	Targeted
Education	Degree, major, institution, date, grade.	High for graduates
Experience	Actions, tools, scale, and results.	High
Courses / Certificates	Relevant and verifiable learning.	Selective
Skills	Named tools and honest levels.	Always
Projects	Problem, contribution, tools, and proof link.	Role dependent
Extracurricular Activities	Role, scale, and outcome.	Optional

Order by strongest relevant evidence.

A fresh graduate may place Education or Projects before Experience. Once relevant work history grows, Experience usually moves higher.

My target role	
My strongest evidence section	
The section I should move higher	
The section I may remove	

05 Open Strong: Contact & Objective



Contact Information

Keep	Remove
Full name; phone; city and country; professional email; customised LinkedIn URL.	Photo unless requested; date of birth; nationality; marital or military status; icon-only labels.

Career Objective Formula

Role	Level	Core Tools	Value
Name the job.	State your level.	Use searchable terms.	Show the employer benefit.

Role I am targeting	
My honest level	
Two core tools from the advert	
Value I can support with evidence	

Reflect & Write

Draft a two- to three-line objective using Role + Level + Core Tools + Value.

06 Turn Experience into Evidence



Education: Five Elements

Degree	Major	Institution	Date	Grade
Write it in full.	Use the specialisation.	Use the official name.	Month/year or study period.	When competitive or requested.

Reverse chronological order.

Put the most recent qualification or role first. Keep role, employer, location, and dates on predictable lines.

Experience Bullet Formula

Action verb + what you did + tool or method + what changed

Weak	Strong
Responsible for the procurement of materials.	Procured materials for three national projects, keeping delivery on schedule.

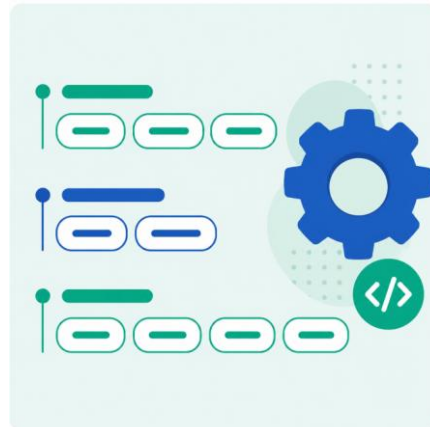
Reflect & Write

Rewrite one weak bullet from your CV. Use scale if you do not have a percentage.

Original bullet:

Rewritten evidence-based bullet:

07 Make Every Supporting Section Earn Its Place



Section	Strong Entry	Cut or Fix
Courses & Certificates	Title, provider, date, and what was covered.	Unrelated courses or attendance-only slips.
Skills	Grouped tools, platforms, languages, and honest levels.	Soft-skill adjectives or vague PC skills.
Projects	Name, problem, your role, tools, features, and a working link.	Broken links or unclear team contribution.

My Evidence Inventory

Certification the target role values	
Three technical skills to name exactly	
Skill level I need to state honestly	
Project problem in plain language	
My contribution to that project	
Working link or proof	

A useful test.

If a skill or project claim cannot become an interview question, it probably should not be on the CV.

Reflect & Write

Which supporting section will improve your match most, and what will you add or remove?

08 Show Contribution, Not Attendance



"What changed because you were there?"

Attendance Language	Evidence Language
Participated in an event.	Coordinated 12 volunteers and delivered the event to 300 attendees.
Managing a team of 100 members.	Managed a team of 100 members.
Working with partner companies.	Built a four-phase programme with seven partners.
Helping with social media.	Reached over 55,000 people through the campaign.

Use past tense for completed work.

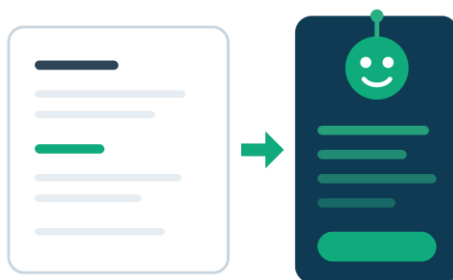
Managed, built, secured, reached, designed, delivered, reduced, tested, documented, and trained state ownership clearly.

Role I held	
Scale: people, projects, or partners	
Action I owned	
Outcome or proof	

Reflect & Write

Rewrite one extracurricular or volunteer entry as a role with scope and a result.

09 AI CV Lab: Tailor, Verify, Humanise



AI Can	AI Must Not
Find missing keywords; shorten bullets; critique and score a draft.	Invent an experience, number, result, skill, or claim you cannot defend.

Four-Step Review

Step	Action	Evidence Check
1. Feed	Paste the advert and anonymised CV text.	Target one exact role.
2. Map	Extract must-have and nice-to-have terms.	Mark proved vs. missing.
3. Rewrite	Use action + task + tool + result.	Verify every number.
4. Score	Ask for gaps and high-impact changes.	Delete claims you cannot defend.

Ready-to-Use Prompt

Act as an ATS screening tool and a technical recruiter. Job advert: [paste advert]. My CV: [paste anonymised CV].

1) List must-have and nice-to-have keywords. 2) Mark which my CV proves and which are missing. 3) Rewrite my 5 weakest bullets as action verb + task + tool + measurable result. 4) Give a match score out of 100 and the 3 highest-impact changes.

Human Quality Check

- ☐ I replaced personal data with placeholders.
- ☐ Every experience and figure comes from my real history.
- ☐ The final wording sounds like me and fits the advert.

Most important missing keyword	
Bullet I rebuilt and verified	
Highest-impact change	

10 Layout Rules & Final CV Check



Length One to two pages; one is ideal for many fresh graduates.	Font Clean and readable: 10-12 pt body; 14-16 pt name.	Spacing Comfortable margins and white space.
Consistency One date, heading, and emphasis style.	Bullets Achievements, not paragraphs.	Single Column No side panels, text boxes, or rating bars.

The Final CV Checklist

- ☐ No photo unless the employer asks for one.
- ☐ Reverse chronological order, newest first.
- ☐ Standard headings and bullet points throughout.
- ☐ No copied claims or evidence from another person.
- ☐ No tables, columns, graphics, or icon-only contact details.
- ☐ Send PDF unless the employer requests Word.
- ☐ Name the file Firstname-Lastname-Role.pdf.

My CV length	
Formatting issue I will fix first	
Final file name	
Requested submission format	

Reflect & Write

What is the one CV change most likely to improve your chance of being shortlisted?

11 Understand the Interview Scorecard



A Competency-Based Interview	What It Changes for You
Uses a prepared list of questions.	The process is comparable and predictable.
Tests one skill in each question.	Prepare an example for each competency.
Scores answers against criteria.	A specific example beats a charming general answer.

Prepare examples, not personality.

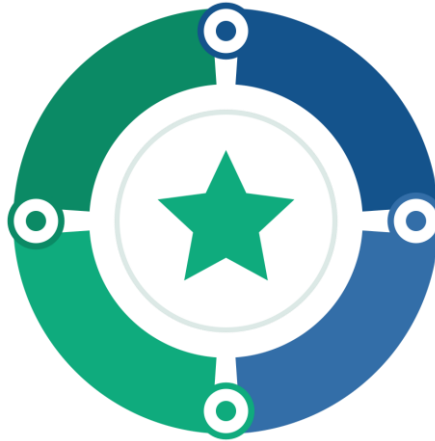
The job advert is the syllabus. Underline teamwork, problem solving, communication, pressure, initiative, and adaptability, then prepare evidence for each.

Question Bank

Question	What It Tests
Introduce yourself.	Can you be concise and relevant?
Why this role and this company?	Do you understand the role and did you research?
What is your biggest achievement?	Can you structure evidence?
Give an example of teamwork or a challenge.	Can you prove a competency?
What would you do if ...?	Can you apply judgement to a hypothetical?

Competency I can prove strongly	
Competency that needs a better example	
Question I expect for my target role	

12 Prepare for the Interview



Focus	What to Prepare	My Evidence
Role	Read the advert and extract the competencies.	
Company	Research what they do and what changed recently.	
Stories	Prepare one real example per important skill.	
Practice	Say your introduction and answers out loud.	
Questions	Prepare two or three questions about the role or team.	
Logistics	Check time, location/link, camera, audio, and background.	

My Three-Day Preparation Plan

When	Research	Examples & Practice	Logistics
3 days before			
1 day before			
Interview day			

My 90-second introduction focus	
Two questions I will ask	
Person I can practise with	

Reflect & Write

What part of interview preparation do you usually skip, and what will you do differently?

13 Build Answers with STAR

S Situation	T Task	A Action	R Result
_____	_____	_____	_____

STAR Part	What to Include	My Draft
Situation	Context in one or two sentences.	
Task	The problem or responsibility that was yours.	
Action	What you did, in the first person. This is the longest part.	
Result	The outcome, with a number wherever possible.	

Keep Situation and Task short.

Action and Result are what the interviewer is marking. Describe the team context, then say what I did - not only what we did.

Competency this story proves	
Number, scale, or evidence in the result	
Follow-up question I should expect	

Reflect & Write

Draft one complete STAR answer for a real example from your experience.

Situation + Task:

Action:

Result:

14 AI Interview Lab: Rehearse & Rebuild

Step	Action	Output
1. Set the scene	Give the AI the advert and anonymised CV.	Role-specific interviewer
2. Run the mock	Answer five questions, one at a time.	Five spoken rehearsals
3. Get scored	Score Situation, Task, Action, and Result.	Evidence gaps
4. Rebuild	Rewrite the two weakest answers using real evidence.	Rehearsal plan

Ready-to-Use Prompt

Act as the hiring manager interviewing me for this role: [paste advert]. This is my anonymised CV: [paste CV]. Ask me 5 competency-based questions, one at a time, and wait for my answer before the next. After each answer, score it out of 5 on Situation, Task, Action and Result, and say exactly what evidence is missing. At the end, name the 2 answers I should rebuild first.

STAR Scorecard

Question / Competency	S	T	A	R	Evidence to Add
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					

Rehearsal Quality Check

- ☐ I answered out loud before typing.
- ☐ Every story and result comes from my real history.
- ☐ I rebuilt the two answers with the weakest evidence.
- ☐ I will also practise with a person who can interrupt and probe.

Reflect & Write

Which STAR element lost the most marks, and what evidence will you add?

15 My CV & Interview Starter Kit



The evidence behind both must be real.

The CV gets you the interview. The interview can get you the offer. AI can shorten the drafting, but it cannot supply your experience.

Starter Kit Summary

Target role	
Job advert selected	
Three keywords to add honestly	
Strongest evidence-based bullet	
CV section to rebuild first	
Competency story to rehearse	
Person I will practise with	
Application date within 72 hours	

My Personal Commitment

Reflect & Write

Complete this sentence: Within the next 72 hours, I will...

My first action:

Evidence that will show it is done:

Before I Apply

- ☐ Tailor one CV to one real job.
- ☐ Run the final ATS and layout checklist, then save the requested format.
- ☐ Prepare four to six competency stories and rehearse two STAR answers out loud.
- ☐ Submit the tailored application within 72 hours.